

137. To my mind it is a wise rule, as also is the following—that the king shall not put any one to death for a single fault, and that none of the Persians shall visit a single fault in a slave with any extreme penalty ; but in every case the services of the offender shall be set against his misdoings ; and, if the latter be found to outweigh the former, the aggrieved party shall then proceed to punishment.¹

138. The Persians maintain that never yet did any one kill his own father or mother ; but in all such cases they are quite sure that, if matters were sifted to the bottom, it would be found that the child was either a changeling or else the fruit of adultery ; for it is not likely they say that the real father should perish by the hands of his child.

139. They hold it unlawful to talk of any thing which it is unlawful to do. The most disgraceful thing in the world, they think, is to tell a lie ; the next worse, to owe a debt : because, among other reasons, the debtor is obliged to tell lies. If a Persian has the leprosy² he is not allowed to enter into a city, or to have any dealings with the other Persians ; he must, they say, have sinned against the sun. Foreigners attacked by this disorder, are forced to leave the country : even white pigeons are often driven away, as guilty of the same offence. They never defile a river with the secretions of their bodies, nor even wash their hands in one ; nor will they allow others to do so, as they have a great reverence for rivers. There is another peculiarity, which the Persians themselves have never noticed, but which has not escaped my observation. Their names, which are expressive of some bodily or mental excellence,³ all end with the same letter—the letter which is called San by the Dorians, and Sigma

¹ Vide infra, vii. 194.

² In the original, two kinds of leprosy are mentioned, the λέπρα and the λεύκη. There does not appear by the description which Aristotle gives of the latter (Hist. Animal. iii. 11) to have been any essential difference between them. The λεύκη was merely a mild form of leprosy. With the Persian isolation of the leper, compare the Jewish practice (Lev. xiii. 46. 2 Kings vii. 3. xv. 5. Luke xvii. 12).

³ It is apparent from this passage that Herodotus had not any very exact acquaintance with the Persian language ; for though it is true enough the Persian names have all a meaning (as the Greek names also have), yet it is rarely that the etymology can be traced to denote physical or mental qualities. They more usually indicate a glorious or elevated station, or dependance on the gods, or worldly possessions. See the list of Persian names occurring in Herodotus and other writers in the notes appended to Book vi.—[H. C. R.]

⁴ The Phœnician alphabet, from which the Greeks adopted theirs (infra, v. 58), possessed both *san* (Heb. *shin*) and *sigma* (Heb. *samech*). The Greeks, not having the sound of *sh*, did not need the two sibilants, and therefore soon merged them in one, retaining however both in their system of numeration, till they replaced *sigma* by *xi*. The Dorians called the sibilant which was kept *san*, the Ionians *sigma*, but the latter use prevailed. The letter came to be generally known as *sigma*, but at